

GRADE 7 · READING LITERATURE · RL.7.7

Text vs. Media

Compare and contrast a written story and its film version, analyzing how techniques unique to each medium create different effects on the audience.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RL.7.7: Compare and contrast a written story and its film version, analyzing h...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

Written stories use words to build internal thoughts, pacing, and detail directly in a reader's mind. Film uses techniques words cannot: camera angles, music, editing, and actors' expressions. Comparing the two means noticing what each medium can do that the other cannot, not just what is "missing."

Modeled Example

A written story describes a character's racing thoughts in a full paragraph. How might a film show the same racing thoughts without narration?

Through quick, choppy editing (fast cuts), a shaky camera, or tense background music — visual and audio techniques that suggest urgency without describing it in words.

A film uses a slow zoom on a character's face during a tense moment. What is a written story's equivalent technique?

A written story might slow the pacing with short, deliberate sentences or describe small physical details (a held breath, a twitching hand) to build the same tension.

The Long Second (written story)

1. Marisol had run the four hundred meters eleven times that season, and every time, the last fifty meters felt the same: her legs turning to something heavier than legs, her lungs arguing loudly with the rest of her body.
2. This time was different only because it was the regional final, and because Devonte, the runner she had never beaten, was exactly one stride ahead of her with sixty meters left.
3. She thought about her coach's voice from a hundred practices: don't chase the runner, chase the finish line. She thought about it for exactly as long as it took to decide it was useless advice with sixty meters left in a race this close.
4. Her legs did not get lighter. Her lungs did not stop arguing. But at the twenty-meter mark, she stopped counting Devonte's stride and started counting her own, one two one two, until counting was the only thought left in her head.
5. She crossed the line eight one-hundredths of a second before he did. She did not know this until she saw the number on the board, because for the last ten meters, she had not been able to see anything but the white line rushing toward her.
6. Devonte found her afterward, both of them still catching their breath. "Eight hundredths," he

The Long Second

EXT. TRACK — REGIONAL FINAL — DAY

Wide shot: eight runners rounding the final curve. The crowd noise SWELLS. Camera cuts to MARISOL, close on her face — jaw tight, eyes locked forward.

Quick cut to DEVONTE, one stride ahead. His shadow falls across Marisol's lane as the camera pans low, tracking their feet.

The score fades out. Only footsteps and breathing remain, mixed unnaturally loud.

MATCH CUT: Marisol's eyes, extreme close-up. A memory flash — three frames only — of her coach mid-sentence, no audio.

Back to real time. The editing speeds up: quick cuts between her feet, Devonte's shoulder, the white finish line rushing closer, each shot shorter than the last.

SLOW MOTION as she crosses the line. Sound cuts out completely for one beat.

Then: the crowd roar rushes back in, full volume. Marisol doubles over, hands on knees, not looking at the board yet.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What internal detail from paragraph 3 of the written story does the film represent as a memory flash instead?
2. Why might the film choose a silent, three-frame memory flash instead of dialogue for the coach's advice?

Guided Practice

3. What technique does the film use to represent Marisol's narrowed focus that the written story achieves through counting ("one two one two")?

4. How does the written story build tension using sentence length and structure in paragraph 4?

Guided Practice

5. What film technique described in the scene mirrors that same building tension?

6. How does the written story convey that Marisol could not see anything but the finish line (paragraph 5)?

Partner Discussion

7. What specific film technique conveys a similar narrowed perception?

8. Why is a technique like "sound cutting out" unique to film and not something a written story can literally do?

Partner Discussion

9. How does the written story handle the moment Marisol learns she won, compared to the film scene?

Independent Practice

10. Which version creates more suspense about the race's outcome for its audience, and why?

11. What does the written story include after the race (paragraph 6) that the film excerpt does not show?

Independent Practice

12. Why might a screenwriter still choose to include that same dialogue scene in a later part of the film, even though it works differently on screen?

13. How does camera movement described in the scene ("panning low, tracking their feet") do work that the written story instead does with description?

Independent Practice

14. What effect does removing the crowd noise ("the score fades out... only footsteps and breathing remain") have on the audience, compared to the written story's equivalent moment?

15. Identify one technique unique to the written medium (something film cannot easily replicate) used in this story.

Small-Group Work

16. Identify one technique unique to the film medium (something the written story cannot literally do) used in this scene.

17. How do both versions still successfully convey the same core emotional experience, despite using different tools?

Small-Group Work

18. Compare how each medium represents the passage of "the long second" referenced in the title.

19. If you were adapting the post-race dialogue scene (paragraph 6) into a film shot, what one technique would you use and why?

Exit Ticket

20. Write two or three sentences comparing one technique from each medium and its specific effect on the audience.

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. Her coach's advice, "don't chase the runner, chase the finish line" — the written story explains it in full sentences, while the film shows it as a brief, silent memory flash.
2. It preserves the scene's tension and pace, since stopping for spoken dialogue mid-race would break the urgency the fast editing is building.
3. Quick, shortening cuts between her feet, Devonte's shoulder, and the finish line — the increasing edit speed visually mimics narrowing, intensifying focus.
4. It uses short, repeated phrases ("Her legs did not get lighter. Her lungs did not stop arguing.") and ends with the simple repetition "one two one two," mirroring urgency through pacing rather than visuals.
5. The increasingly fast cuts and shortening shot lengths near the finish line mirror the same rising urgency the prose builds through short sentences.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. It states directly: "she had not been able to see anything but the white line rushing toward her."
7. The slow motion during the finish line crossing, combined with sound cutting out completely for one beat, isolates that single visual and moment for the audience.
8. Written stories cannot remove sound because they contain no sound at all; instead, they must describe silence or a lack of awareness using words, which creates a different kind of effect.
9. The written story explains it after the fact — "She did not know this until she saw the number on the board" — using retrospective narration, while the film holds on the scoreboard for two full seconds before showing Marisol's reaction, building suspense visually in real time.
10. Answers vary; a reasonable case can be made either way — the written story's retrospective phrasing already implies she found out something, while the film's held shot on the scoreboard creates real-time suspense for the viewer.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. The full dialogue between Marisol and Devonte about "eight hundredths" and what it means, which is described in the written story but is not part of the provided film scene description.

12. Actors' tone, facial expressions, and pauses could add layers (uncertainty, respect, humor) that the written dialogue alone conveys through described reactions like "he laughed."

13. The written story describes the physical feeling of running (heavy legs, arguing lungs) in words, while the camera pan shows the physical action of the runners' feet directly to the viewer.

14. It isolates the audience's attention on Marisol's physical effort, similar to how the written story narrows focus onto her counting, but the film achieves it through sound design instead of narrated thought.

15. Direct access to Marisol's internal thoughts, like her private decision that her coach's advice was "useless advice with sixty meters left" — this interior reasoning is stated directly in prose in a way film usually has to imply through action or voiceover.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. The "sound cuts out completely for one beat," a literal audio technique only available in a medium that has sound.

17. Both build increasing tension and narrowed focus as the race nears its end, then release that tension at the finish line — the written story through pacing and repetition, the film through editing speed and sound design.

18. The written story slows this moment with detailed internal narration across two full paragraphs; the film represents it using slow motion and a sound cutout, both techniques designed to stretch a brief moment for the audience.

19. Answers vary; require a specific film technique (close-up, pause, music cue, etc.) and a clear explanation of how it would convey the same meaning as the written dialogue.

20. Answers vary; require one clearly identified technique from the written story, one from the film scene, and an explanation of each one's specific effect, not just a general statement that they are "different."

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer